



AT ACTIONHA CAFE in Deir al Balah in the Gaza Strip, a money broker cashes paychecks for a commission. People in the area have started going from broker to broker to find the one who takes the smallest cut.

Broke in Gaza? There are fixes, but they’ll cost you

As paper money disintegrates and ATMs lie buried in rubble, desperate Palestinians find ways to stretch — and patch — shekels

By Bilal Shbair and Nabih Bulos



SOME PALESTINIANS use money brokers, and others take their tattered cash to a Gaza jeweler who has perfected the art of gluing it back together.

DEIR AL BALAH, Gaza Strip — The tools of his new-found trade arrayed before him, Mohammad Al-Ashqar, a jeweler for decades, prepares himself for the first of some 200 intricate repairs he performs every day. In his hand he holds neither gemstone nor gold, but a gossamer-thin 20-shekel note held together with tape.

He takes an X-Acto knife, carefully peels off the old tape, cleans the residue, then applies transparent glue in a way to ensure the bill doesn't break when it's folded.

"It's not easy," Al-Ashqar, 48, says of his work as a money repairman in a shop in Deir al Balah. "But I've become quite good at it."

More than a year into Israel's bombardment of the Gaza Strip, cash is king. But the destruction across the Palestinian territory, which has left few banks standing and made ATMs inaccessible, along with Israel's blocking of bill and coin transfers in and out of the enclave, also means cash is scarce.

"People have been passing around the same bills for more than a year now," says Al-Ashqar, who was dis-

After serving time, ex-USC official says she was a scapegoat

'I did my job description' to help rich kids, admissions liaison says

By Harriet Ryan and Matt Hamilton

When Donna Heinel arrived at the federal prison camp in Victorville last year to serve a six-month sentence for fraud stemming from the Varsity Blues admissions scandal, she resolved to spend the time productively. She walked two miles in the morning, ran three miles in the afternoon and tutored inmates studying for their high school equivalency exams.

No matter how busy she made herself, though, her thoughts always returned to the same question: How had she, a respected USC administrator, become the criminal companion of morally bankrupt one-percenters and an outcast from the institution she had long revered?

Like one retracing her steps to find something lost, Heinel started writing down everything she could re-

member about her career and its implosion, exhausting 20 pencils and five notebooks.

"Nothing made sense," Heinel said. "USC was my life."

What she ultimately concluded, the now 63-year-old said in her first media interview since her 2019 arrest, was that she became a scapegoat for USC's longstanding treatment of affluent applicants, a system the Varsity Blues scandal threatened to expose.

She told The Times she handled the wealthy times she brought to her by corrupt college counselor Rick Singer in similar fashion to hundreds of other well-off applicants USC sent her way as potential sources of donations. Her superiors not only knew about the special treatment but also encouraged it.

D.A. plans to fire special prosecutor

Inquiries into killings by police will be handled by previously tasked division, raising accountability issue.

By James Queally

Los Angeles County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman says he intends to terminate the contract of a special prosecutor that George Gascón hired to reopen investigations into fatal police shootings, a move that could shake up high-profile cases that involve controversial killings by officers.

The district attorney's office said in a statement that

it will "no longer be using" the services of Lawrence Middleton, a former federal prosecutor who convicted several Los Angeles police officers of violating Rodney King's civil rights after they were acquitted in state court in the 1991 beating of the Black motorist.

Middleton was brought on by former Dist. Atty. Gascón in 2021 to reconsider charges in four separate shootings that former Dist. Atty. Jackie Lacey's administration declined to prosecute. Middleton's contract expires in June, but Hochman has "the option to terminate" the agreement early and is in discussions with county lawyers to do so, the district attorney's office said.

A requiem for L.A. County's unclaimed dead

Ceremony honors 1,865 this year. The number has grown amid an epidemic of loneliness.

By Corinne Purtill

On a grassy hillside just east of downtown Los Angeles, a few dozen mourners gathered last week to pay respects to 1,865 people whose names they did not know — men, women and children whose ashes recently joined the remains of 100,000 others laid to rest here since 1896.

The departed interred at Los Angeles County Cemetery had one thing in common, and one thing separating them from those on the other side of the rusty chain-link fence demarcating the county plot and neighboring Evergreen Cemetery: They had neither the means for a private burial nor family to claim their bodies.

Each December, those whose remains have been unclaimed for three years are memorialized with an interfaith ceremony. On Thursday, members of the



THE CEREMONY of the Unclaimed Dead is held at the Los Angeles County Cemetery, where 1,865 unclaimed decedents were laid to rest in a communal grave.

public looked on in respectful silence as representatives of L.A. County's many faiths acknowledged the dead the way they might have wanted: with a Buddhist chant, a smudging of sage, the Lord's Prayer in Swahili, Hindi and Spanish.

The blessings said over the freshly turned earth hinted at the lives once lived. Many were unhoused. A small handful were never identified. Some were children.

Brian Donnelly drove from Hollywood to witness the ceremony. He suspects a number of the unhoused people he's come to know from his neighborhood over the years are interred here, he said.

"I think it's important," he said of the ceremony, his voice catching. "You come into this world with somebody. You don't deserve to go out alone."

Newsom's failed climate pledge
Despite what he said in 2019, Aliso Canyon gas field is still operating, Sammy Roth writes. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

College unions rush to organize
Labor leaders on California campuses worry a Trump White House won't be friendly to them. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Chargers routed by Tampa Bay
The 40-17 loss at home, fueled by Buccaneers' Mayfield, dims playoff hopes for L.A. in wild-card race. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 71/48. **B5**

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